Common wrestling penalties

Mat Rats and Valkyries families • Grindstone Wrestling Club

Penalty points are added to the opponent's score. Cautions and warnings may leave the score unchanged. These are standard NFHS folkstyle rules; ask the coach about any youth or event modifications.

False starts and starting position. Moving before the whistle or lining up incorrectly for a restart. These share two cautions per wrestler per match; each later infraction gives the opponent 1 point.

Stalling. Not making an honest effort to wrestle, such as avoiding action. It has its own sequence: warning, 1 point, 1 point, 2 points, then disqualification. Being behind or getting stuck is not automatically stalling.

Locked hands. From top, illegally locking or overlapping hands or arms around the opponent's body or both legs. Standing, lifting and near-fall exceptions apply; the referee judges the position.

Grabbing gear and other technical violations. Grabbing the singlet or headgear is prohibited. Going or forcing an opponent out to avoid imminent scoring can be the technical violation of fleeing the mat; an ordinary boundary restart is different.

Illegal holds. A prohibited hold or force beyond a joint's normal range, such as a full nelson. A referee can stop a potentially dangerous position before it becomes illegal without awarding a penalty point.

Unnecessary roughness and unsportsmanlike conduct. Examples include unnecessary force, taunting or abusive behavior by a wrestler during the match. A serious act of flagrant misconduct can cause immediate disqualification.

How repeated penalties work

Locked hands, gear-grabbing and other technical violations, illegal holds, unnecessary roughness and wrestler unsportsmanlike conduct during the match share one cumulative sequence: 1 point, 1 point, 2 points, then disqualification (loss of the match). There is no initial warning in this sequence. Switching to a different violation does not restart the count. Stalling and starting cautions are counted separately, as above.

A whistle does not always mean a penalty

A normal out-of-bounds restart, stalemate or safety stop can carry no penalty points. In neutral, the referee distinguishes ordinary boundary action from stalling such as backing out or pushing or pulling an opponent out to avoid wrestling. Watch the referee and scoreboard; let your coach handle questions.

NFHS Rules 5, 7 and 8, including the penalty charts; read with later changes. USA Wrestling folkstyle section 25 uses NFHS rules with modifications. Checked September 26, 2026.

USA Wrestling folkstyle / NFHS rulebook and charts / Current NFHS changes